

“From being a consumer of open source India is now a significant contributor to it”



As I waited at the coffee shop to interview one of India's pioneering open source experts in Gurugram (Gurgaon), a slim man walked towards me and with a pleasant smile, asked if I was **Syeda Beenish** from **OSFY**. As we chatted about technology and open source, I could sense that **Kishore Bhargava**, **CEO, Linkaxis Technologies**, and an early adopter of FOSS, was an excellent leader. He had no airs about him, and his deep understanding of technology left me spellbound. Over a cup of coffee, he recounted his journey in India's software industry and talked about how open source has evolved in India. The excerpts...

The journey began with 'What Next?'

The first time I came to know about open source seems like a long, long time ago. Let me take you back in time! Way back in late 1987, we managed to get access to ERNET (Education and Research Network, set up in 1986 by the then Department of Electronics). Apart from access, we also got so involved that we started helping the ERNET members by fixing issues for them. This was when we came to know that the global market was getting ready with a much more affordable, or rather, a free alternative to UNIX (a costly affair then). Linux, as it was called, excited us.

In fact, in 1991, I, along with three friends, who were all Linux enthusiasts, painfully managed to download the SLS 0.91, the first Linux distribution package onto 41 floppies. After

downloading it, the first thing that came to our mind was, "What next?"

This question created a distance between me and Linux, as I did not know what to do with it. Years later, I was in the US attending a seminar where free copies of Slackware were distributed. On coming back home I realised the enormous potential and the possibilities it was open to. And since then, Linux has been an integral part of my life.

I fell in love with open source software only on the second encounter

Though open source software excited me, we could not go along with it initially. But after my encounter with Slackware in 1994, there has been no looking back. I feel happy to be one of the very few early adopters of FOSS in India. But after tasting open source, I wanted others also to enjoy it and make

use of the many benefits it offers. In fact, I feel it's the efforts of many like-minded people that helped open source evolve from being considered a 'strange thing' to becoming mainstream.

I am a technology consultant with over 30 years of experience in the areas of communications, messaging solutions, application design and deployment, security systems and planning, and strategy. My core speciality lies in network architecture, security, unified messaging, project management, IT planning and strategy. I have successfully assisted several global corporations, as well as non-governmental organisations in defining their technology roadmaps and installing world-class solutions for their operations in India and globally. Needless to say, all of this was done using free and open source software and technologies.